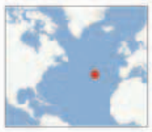
ANGLO–SPANISH WARS

AZORES



Date August 30-31, 1591
Forces Spanish: 53 ships; English: c.20 ships
Losses Spanish: 1 ship sunk; English: 1 ship captured

Location Off Flores island, Azores

In spring 1591 an English fleet under Lord Thomas Howard set sail for the Azores, hoping to intercept the annual Spanish treasure fleet. Howard's second-in-command was Sir Richard Grenville, a soldier and privateer of an arrogant and violent disposition, feared by his enemies and his own men alike. Grenville was on board *Revenge*, widely respected as one of the finest galleons in the world. While Howard waited at the Azores for a treasure fleet that never came, a large force of warships assembled in the Spanish port of Ferrol, commanded by Don Alonso de Bazán, a brother of the deceased Marqués de Santa Cruz.

Bazán reached the Azores in late August. The English were weary with waiting, many of their crew struck down by disease. They had landed their sick on Flores island and were taking on water and cleaning out their bilges when they learned that a Spanish fleet was approaching. Bazán had cleverly split his force in two, sending ships around both sides of the island to catch his enemy in a pincer movement. The English were just ready to make sail when the Spanish appeared around a headland at 5:00 p.m. Howard led a dash to open sea between the pincers of Bazán's trap. One ship lagged behind: Grenville's *Revenge*. As the trap closed, Grenville attempted to break through the mass of Spanish ships. Rammed by the galleon *San Felipe*, he was trapped, while Howard led the rest of the English fleet away to safety.

The struggle that followed was an epic of resistance by Grenville's crew. Grappled by another galleon, *San Barnabe*, and surrounded by four others, she fought off repeated attempts to board, even succeeding in sinking one Spanish ship. Wounded in the head, Grenville insisted on continuing resistance, although it was evidently hopeless. The following morning his crew disobeyed his order to blow up the ship and surrendered. Grenville died of his wounds; *Revenge* sank in a gale two weeks later.



Defying the odds
The last stand of the *Revenge* was the kind of heroic tale told again and again to inspire patriotism in generations of English schoolboys.

WITNESS TO WAR

SIR WALTER RALEIGH

ENGLISH NAVAL COMMANDER

LAST FIGHT OF THE REVENGE IN THE AZORES

"Sir Richard finding himself in this distress, and unable any longer to make resistance, having endured in this ***fifteen hours fight****, the assault of fifteen several Armadoes, all by turns aboard him, and by estimation* ***eight hundred shot of great artillery****, besides many assaults and entries … commanded the Master Gunner, whom he knew to be a most resolute man, to split and sink the ship; that thereby* ***nothing might remain of glory or victory to the Spaniards****: seeing in so many hours fight, and with so great a Navy they were not able to take her, having had fifteen hours time,* ***fifteen thousand men****, and* ***fifty and three sail of men of war*** *to perform it withal."*

ANGLO–SPANISH WARS

CARIBBEAN



Date August 1595–January 1596
Forces English: 26 ships; Spanish: unknown
Losses Unknown

Location The Caribbean

In 1595 the aging Sir Francis Drake and Sir John Hawkins planned a return to privateering. They would raid Spanish colonies in the Caribbean, combining private profit with damage to the Spanish war effort. The two leaders of the expedition, strong-willed contrasting characters, soon fell to arguing. Drake insisted on attacking Grand Canary island en route, but an attempted landing failed in the face of stiff resistance. They then crossed the Atlantic to attack the port of San Juan in Puerto Rico, hoping to capture a disabled Spanish treasure ship sheltering in the harbor. When they arrived off San Juan, Hawkins died of a fever. The Spanish authorities on the island had been warned of their approach and the defenses were too strong for Drake's force to overcome. In search of easier prey they shifted to the mainland, going ashore at Nombre de Dios, but when the expedition's land commander, Sir Thomas Baskerville, led a march on Panama he met stiff resistance and had to turn back. Drake refused to give up, saying: "We must have gold before we reach England." He died of dysentery off Puerto Bello on January 28, 1596. The expedition was a fiasco, although Baskerville brought most of the ships home.

ANGLO–SPANISH WARS

CADIZ



Date July 20–June 5, 1596
Forces English and Dutch: 120 ships; Spanish: unknown
Losses English: none; Spanish: 2 ships sunk, 2 captured

Location Cadiz, Spain

On June 3, 1596, a fleet set sail from Plymouth to attack the Spanish port of Cadiz. Its commanders were Elizabeth I's favorite Robert Devereux, Earl of Essex, and her experienced lord admiral, Lord Howard of Effingham. Also on board was Sir Walter Raleigh, with the post of rear admiral. The queen regarded the expedition as a hopefully self-financing pre-emptive strike against Spanish preparations for a new Armada, but Essex had a more ambitious objective—to seize and hold the port with a permanent garrison. Arriving at Cadiz, the English fought a sharp, successful naval engagement during which competition for glory between rival English commanders was as prominent as hostility to the enemy. Two large Spanish galleons were destroyed and two captured. Essex then stormed the town walls and seized control of Cadiz. His soldiers ransacked the town for valuables—one account describes common soldiers "with their arms full of silk and cloth of gold." But the English failed to seize the rich merchant ships in the inner harbor, which the Spanish were able to scuttle. Howard refused to go along with Essex's plan for a permanent occupation of Cadiz. The English were in any case keen to get their treasure back home. They left on July 5 with the city in flames. The raid was a severe blow to Spanish prestige, but it did not prevent the dispatch of an Armada four months later that was, fortunately for England, forced back by bad weather.



Anglo-Dutch attack on Cadiz
This Dutch engraving of the 1596 attack on Cadiz shows buildings around the port in flames. The Dutch published many such propaganda images of Spain's discomfiture at the hands of its Protestant enemies.